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Despite there being many advances in technical defenses, human behavior remains the leading cause of cybersecurity breaches in corporate environments. Research has shown that risky online habits, susceptibility to social engineering attacks, security fatigue, and heedlessness to training from employees can significantly increase the likelihood of an organization being the target of a breach. This report will outline how human behavior contributes to cyber incidents and will explain why this company's structure increases its exposure to phishing, insider threats, credential theft, and data compromise.

Human Behavior as a Cybersecurity Vulnerability

Cybersecurity incidents are frequently rooted in patterns of human behavior, rather than in technological failures. Research in behavioral cybersecurity has emphasized that cognitive biases, often exposure to a digital lifestyle, and the preference for convenience over security can influence risky behaviors online (Ait Maalem Lahcen et al., 2020; Grobler et al., 2021). People who overuse social media or regularly interact with strangers online experience higher rates of victimization when it comes to cybercrime (Marttila et al., 2021; Herrero et al., 2021).

Marttila et al. (2021) found that individuals who demonstrate a habitual pattern of excessive social media use (better known as problematic social media use or PSMU) report victimization rates of over 40%, compared to the victimization rates of non-problematic social media users. The study also showed that increases in compulsive social media use corresponded with an increase in victimization over time (Marttila et al., 2021). These findings are relevant to employees who actively use social media to promote products, recruit staff, and engage in networking.

Research into Lifestyle and Routine Activity theories regarding digital exposure similarly demonstrates that increased exposure raises the likelihood of meeting motivated offenders while having an absence of a capable guardian (Akdemir & Lawless, 2020). When employees work remotely or travel often, it leaves them with less organizational oversight (absence of a capable guardian) and increases the chances of exposure.

Additionally, studies into insider threats further indicate that negligence, stress, and workflow pressure make significant contributions to the likelihood of breaches (Oladimeji et al., 2019; Saxena et al., 2020). Insider threats are not always malicious actors; lapses in behavior, such as accidental disclosure of sensitive information, weak login credentials, or failure to verify the authenticity of an email account for a large number of insider threats that lead to breaches.

Organizational Risk Factors

Remote Workforce Exposure

With approximately 300 employees working remotely and/or traveling extensively, this organization has a higher risk of being exposed to phishing campaigns and credential compromise. Having remote work settings creates reduced centralized monitoring, which then increases the need for cloud-based platforms and mobile communication. Human-focused cybersecurity research efforts suggest that when usability conflicts with security requirements, employees will often prioritize convenience over security (Grobler et al., 2021). This behavioral tendency increases the company's vulnerability.

Security fatigue worsens this issue. When employees feel overwhelmed by constant security prompts or complicated authentication processes, they often disengage (Nobles, 2022). This reduces their vigilance and lowers the chances that they will be able to identify malicious activity.

High Personal Turnover

Companies with high turnover rates often require continuous onboarding cycles, which, in turn, creates a limitation in the retention of institutional knowledge. Newly hired employees may not have the experience to recognize internal communication patterns, making impersonation attempts much easier to fall for. Research indicates that inexperience and reduced organizational attachment directly correlate with increased cyber vulnerability (Ait Maalem Lahcen et al., 2020).

High turnover rates also increase the risk of insider threats. Studies into insider risk demonstrate that insufficient monitoring and inconsistency with access controls create a higher risk of a breach (Saxena et al., 2020). Without structured protocols for onboarding and offboarding within an organization, access management gaps become more recurrent.

Behavioral Risk Summary

The research findings discussed above are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1

Behavioral Risk Factors and Associated Organizational Impact

Behavioral Variable	Supporting Research	Key Finding	Organizational Risk Impact
Problematic Social Media Use	Marttila et al. (2021)	Over 40% victimization among high-intensity users	Marketing and recruiting staff highly exposed to phishing and impersonation
Increased digital lifestyle exposure	Akdemir and Lawless (2020)	Higher probability of encountering motivated offenders online	Remote employees face increased threat contact
Security fatigue	Nobles (2022)	Behavioral disengagement reduces protective compliance	Alert fatigue decreases phishing detection rates

Insider threat behaviors	Saxena et al. (2020)	Human error and negligence common breach sources	High turnover increases accidental data exposure risk
Human-centric security gaps	Grobler et al. (2021)	Usability pressures influence risky decisions	Employees prioritize convenience over security controls

Note: Adapted from Marttila et al. (2021); Akdemir and Lawless (2020); Nobles (2022); Saxena et al. (2020); Grobler et al. (2021).

As shown in Table 1, behavioral variables such as excessive digital exposure, security fatigue, and insider negligence significantly increase organizational vulnerability. When these factors converge in a company with a large remote workforce and high turnover, breach probability rises substantially.

Implications for This Organization

Based on the company's size and work structure, behavioral vulnerabilities are a high risk. Employees who are public-facing increase their susceptibility to spear-phishing attacks by sharing their professional information online. Remote workers have a higher chance of contact with threat actors because they have reduced oversight. The company's high turnover reduces the employees' familiarity with internal security protocols.

National data further demonstrates the financial consequences of behavior-driven cybercrime. The Federal Bureau of Investigation and Yarbrough (2024) report that Business Email Compromise resulted in losses totaling \$2,770,151,146 in 2024. This category of crime is linked directly to phishing scams and failures in employee verification. These findings reinforce the urgency of implementing controls based on behavior rather than just technology.

Strategic Recommendations

To reduce behavioral-based risks, the organization should implement the following human-centered cybersecurity strategies:

1. Develop role-based, interactive training based on employee access privileges.
2. Conduct quarterly phishing simulations and scenario-based exercises for employees to get hands-on practice.
3. Establish measurable performance indicators such as phishing susceptibility rates and reporting frequency (McNett & McNett, 2025).
4. Implement structured access controls for onboarding and offboarding procedures.
5. Create formal social media governance policies for all employees with public-facing roles.

Human-centered security leadership emphasizes that creating behavioral changes that can be sustained requires reinforcement, measurable outcomes, and alignment between usability and security practices (Triplett, 2022).

Conclusion

Human behavior is the primary driver behind cybersecurity breaches. Factors such as excessive social media and exposure to a digital lifestyle, negligence from employees, security fatigue, and lack of reinforcement on cybersecurity practices all significantly increase vulnerability. For this company, behavior-based exposure to threats is amplified due to the number of employees, mainly remote operations, and high-turnover rates. By adopting a more structured, evidence-based behavioral cybersecurity framework, this organization can significantly reduce the likelihood of breaches and protect its assets.

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